In the last eight years, a parallel effort was made in the Gulf to rebuild other long-standing associations that have been disrupted. After decades of limiting those ties to energy and emigration, India is working at creating full spectrum relationships. Stronger economic linkages are being buttressed by closer security coordination. The IMEC could be a harbinger of a new era.

A third initiative is currently underway and has its own basis, this time aimed at Central Asia. Here, overcoming the impediment of connectivity is central to dealing with a region with such visible cultural affinity. Of course, with regard to the sea space to its south, the 2015 SAGAR doctrine initiated a reach-out to islands whose future is so closely intertwined with India. Returning to history and recognizing our extended neighbourhoods is another reason why India matters.

Political constraints can not only limit the pursuit of national interest but also shrink strategic horizons. To a considerable extent, that had happened in the case of India. As we strive to go beyond the previous framework, it is only natural that the cultural legacies should start to regain salience. The most obvious of these are in respect of Southeast Asia, where centuries of exchanges produced a rich shared heritage. These are visible even today in significant monuments and living arts. Consequently, a new archaeological find in My Son or a conservation project in Angkor Wat, Ta Prohm and Bagan affirms the understandable desire to build further on the past. Towards the East, the extent of the Indian cultural reach goes all the way to South Korea. It is but natural that the cultural revival of Ayodhya should strike a strong chord in that society.

Turning to the West, the expressions of our common history may be a little different but no less a part of societal mores. An energetic culture of trade picks up on old comfort to build new links very quickly. There is an equally intuitive appreciation of the cultural practices of its partners as well. The construction of a temple in Abu Dhabi is symbolic of its time-honoured relationship with Indian society.

The connection in the north to the Eurasian landmass is similarly significant. The spread of Buddhism through the continent carried its own intellectual, spiritual and aesthetic messages. This legacy endures and the endeavour is really to ensure it flowers again. Dedicated efforts have been made in that direction in the last few years, once Indian policy broadened to appreciate its necessity.